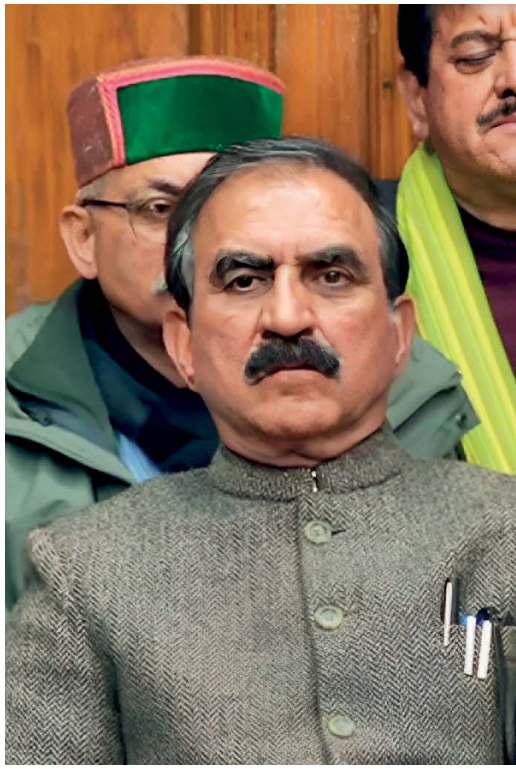
HIMACHAL PRADESH / RAJYA SABHA POLLS

VERTICAL DESCENT FOR CONGRESS

By Anilesh S. Mahajan



It's been a bit of a nerve-wracking rollercoaster ride for the Congress of late, with the latest jolt to its self-image coming from a state it would have deemed relatively peril-free: Himachal Pradesh. But as it realised on February 27, with a Rajya Sabha election that went horribly wrong, no paradise is free of things that move in sudden, unpredictable ways.... As another day rolled by unsteadily in trauma ward, the Grand Old Party was scrambling to save its only solo state government in north India. Home remedy was out of the question, since trouble had erupted precisely because the local unit was caught up in internecine strife. So, Congress troubleshooters from elsewhere—Karnataka strongman D.K. Shivakumar, former Haryana CM Bhupinder S. Hooda, Chhattisgarh's Bhupesh Baghel—were drafted in to impose a modicum of order, and talk to everyone to arrive at a resolution.

As things stood after hectic confabulations late on February 28, Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu had just about erased the question mark put over his continuation. But the rebels, too, had holstered their guns. State PWD minister and son of the late CM Virbhadra Singh, Vikramaditya Singh, who left the Sukhu government teetering on the edge by sending in his resignation, had been mollycoddled enough to take it back. And, in a counter-strike, the budget was passed after 15 BJP legislators were suspended for 'unruly behaviour'. The six Congress MLAs who had cross-voted to defeat party candidate Abhishek Manu Singhvi, too, were suspended, and disqualified a day later.

In retrospect, it was indeed folly for the Congress to imagine Himachal as a state where it needed to fear no ambush. About 15 months ago, when Sukhu was sworn in after a morale-boosting assembly poll victory, he was a freshman, a compromise candidate meant to balance power equations between rival factions. The one who lost out then had been the obvious choice for many: Mandi MP and Virbhadra's widow Pratibha Singh. That heartburn has obviously not eased. On February 27, son Vikramaditya found his opportune moment to strike amidst a most dramatic and shambolic turn of events for the party earlier that day: Singhvi's shock defeat in the Rajya Sabha election from the state. It had come out of the blue, despite the party having a clean majority of 40 MLAs in a 68-seat assembly. The BJP had only 25 legislators. But apart from the six Congress turncoats, three independents who supported the government till then also shifted loyalties. That swelled BJP candidate Harsh Mahajan's numbers to 34—tied with Singhvi. Later, Mahajan won the tiebreaker in a draw of lots.

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